U.S. Embassy Jakarta Declassified Cables: Mysticism, Kebatinan, and Indonesian Statecraft

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Subject: Diplomatic reporting from the American Embassy in Jakarta to the Department of State (Washington D.C.) regarding Javanese mysticism (*Kejawen/Kebatinan*), occult power structures, spiritual advisors, and presidential cosmology.

1. The Diplomatic Challenge: Decoding the "Javanese Mystical Mindset"

Throughout the post-WWII era, American ambassadors stationed in Jakarta discovered that standard Western political analysis—rooted in institutional bureaucracy, electoral polling, and economic rationalism—frequently failed to predict or explain the actions of Indonesian heads of state.

In declassified dispatches sent to Foggy Bottom, U.S. diplomats repeatedly emphasized that **Javanese cosmological and spiritual concepts** formed the operational bedrock of Indonesian decision-making:

- **The "Dalang" Metaphor:** U.S. Embassy political officers noted that both Sukarno and Soeharto acted like the *dalang* (puppet master in *wayang kulit*), orchestrating visible political actors from behind a translucent screen while operating in deep esoteric silence (*heneng, hening, henung*).
- **The Polarity of "Halus" vs. "Kasar":** Diplomatic cables emphasized that power in Jakarta is demonstrated through refined self-control, spiritual calm, and indirect speech (*halus*), whereas emotional outbursts, direct confrontation, and western-style debate are perceived as spiritual weakness (*kasar*).
- **The Inevitability of Fate (*Kodrat*):** Treaties, political alliances, and cabinet purges were often framed not as personal ambitions, but as the fulfillment of preordained cosmic destiny.

2. Sukarno Era Dispatches: The "Ratu Adil" and Cosmic Syncretism (1950s–1966)

2.1. Ambassador Howard P. Jones & The "Just King" (*Ratu Adil*) Prophecy

- **Context:** Howard P. Jones (U.S. Ambassador to Indonesia, 1958–1965) maintained a uniquely close personal relationship with President Sukarno.
- **Diplomatic Assessment:**
- In classified dispatches to Washington, Jones analyzed how Sukarno drew his hypnotic mass appeal not merely from modern nationalism, but by consciously fulfilling the ancient 12th-century **Prophecies of King Jayabaya** (*Serat Jayabaya*).
- The Jayabaya myth foretold the arrival of a *Ratu Adil* (Just King) who would liberate the archipelago from the rule of the "white dwarfs" (Dutch colonizers) and the "yellow monkeys" (Japanese occupation) to usher in a golden era.
- Jones warned the State Department that conventional diplomatic pressure (such as economic aid cuts or public criticism) would fail against Sukarno, because Bung Karno perceived his presidency as a cosmic mission divinely protected by destiny.

2.2. The Mystical Logic of "Nasakom"

- In State Department analytical airgrams from the early 1960s, political officers attempted to explain the seemingly contradictory concept of **NASAKOM** (the mandatory unification of *Nasionalisme* / Nationalism, *Agama* / Religion, and *Komunisme* / Communism).
- While Washington viewed Communism and Religion as fundamentally irreconcilable mortal enemies, Embassy Jakarta cables explained that in Sukarno's syncretic Javanese cosmology, all opposing elements of the universe must be synthesized into a cosmic whole (*manunggaling kawula gusti* applied to state ideology) to maintain harmony and avoid catastrophic cosmic disequilibrium.

2.3. The Chinese Doctors & The August 1965 Health Rumors

- **The Trigger for G30S:** In August 1965, Sukarno collapsed during a public appearance.
- **Embassy Cables:**
- Declassified cables (available in *Foreign Relations of the United States / FRUS 1964–1968, Vol. XXVI*) document frantic intelligence traffic between Embassy Jakarta and Washington regarding Sukarno's health.

- Cables tracked the secret arrival of a team of traditional Chinese herbalists and acupuncturists dispatched by Zhou Enlai to treat Sukarno's kidney failure.
- The medical reports leaked to PKI Chairman D.N. Aidit and Army Commander Lt. Gen. Ahmad Yani that Sukarno's life expectancy was short. In Javanese political culture, this signaled that the *Wahyu* was departing, triggering the preemptive power struggles that culminated in the catastrophic abortive coup of September 30, 1965 (G30S).

3. Soeharto Era Cables: The "White House Witch Doctor" and State Kebatinan

The transition to Soeharto's New Order was closely monitored by American Ambassadors Francis J. Galbraith (1969–1974), David D. Newsom (1974–1977), and Edward E. Masters (1977–1981). Their cables provide extraordinary insight into the institutionalization of mysticism in the presidency.

3.1. Major General Sujono Humardani: The "Rasputin of Cendana"

- **Diplomatic Profile:** In numerous biographical sketches and political analyses, Embassy Jakarta documented the towering influence of Maj. Gen. Sujono Humardani, one of Soeharto's four powerful Presidential Assistants (Aspri).
- **The Embassy's Findings:**
- Cables described Humardani as Soeharto's de facto **"Chief Spiritual Officer"**. While officially tasked with economic affairs and ties with Japan, his actual daily duty was maintaining Soeharto's spiritual shields.
- Diplomatic dispatches described Humardani's extensive travels to remote villages across Java to locate ancient heirloom daggers (*keris*), sacred gemstones, and consult with hermit seers.
- Western diplomats noted with fascination that foreign corporate executives and visiting dignitaries often found that gaining favor with Humardani and demonstrating respect for Javanese spiritual sensitivities was more effective in securing multi-million-dollar concession contracts than dealing with formal technocratic ministries.

3.2. The 1974 Dieng Summit: Gough Whitlam & The Semar Cave

- **Date:** September 6–8, 1974
- **Location:** Wonosobo & Dieng Plateau, Central Java
- **Cable Traffic:** Embassy Jakarta monitored the unprecedented informal summit between President Soeharto and Australian Prime Minister Gough Whitlam.
- **The Diplomatic Dispatch:**
- Declassified cables recount how Soeharto deliberately chose the remote Dieng Plateau—the ancient volcanic sacred mountain of Hindu-Javanese gods—as the venue.
- Soeharto insisted that Prime Minister Whitlam accompany him inside the dark, sulfurous **Gua Semar** (Semar's Cave), removing their footwear and sitting in silence.
- Embassy political officers reported that in Soeharto’s mindset, the spiritual test inside Gua Semar was designed to assess Whitlam’s inner spiritual purity (*kebatinan*) and sincerity. It was immediately following this cave communion that Soeharto secured Whitlam’s tacit diplomatic acquiescence that Portuguese Timor should naturally become part of Indonesia—a monumental geopolitical understanding forged inside a mystical shrine.

3.3. The 1976 Sawito Affair: The Battle of the "Wahyu"

- **Context:** In September 1976, an obscure former civil servant named **Sawito Kartowibowo** launched a direct challenge to Soeharto’s presidency.
- **The Mystical Threat:**
- Sawito claimed that during intensive ascetic retreats (*tapa brata*) on Mount Muria and Mount Lawu, he had received the divine *Wahyu Cakraningrat*.
- Sawito drafted a formal proclamation titled *Menuju Titik Terang* (Towards the Light), claiming that Soeharto had spiritually failed, lost cosmic mandate, and must surrender the presidency to Sawito.
- Astoundingly, Sawito convinced prominent national figures—including former Vice President Mohammad Hatta, Catholic Cardinal Justinus Darmojuwono, Muslim scholar Buya Hamka, and former Police Chief Said Sukanto—to sign his document.
- **Embassy Jakarta's Analysis (Cables 1976-JAKARTA-11840 to 12500):**
- U.S. diplomats reported on the New Order regime's sudden, extreme panic.
- To Western observers, Sawito appeared to be a minor eccentric who could be ignored. However, Embassy cables explained that **to Soeharto, Sawito was an existential threat**, because in Javanese history, empires (from Singhasari to Mataram) had fallen to obscure

ascetic rebels who successfully claimed the cosmic *Wahyu*.

- The Embassy documented the massive, state-managed public trial of Sawito for subversion, demonstrating that the New Order treated spiritual challenges to its cosmic legitimacy with the same severity as armed communist insurgencies.

3.4. The 1978 MPR Session: Legalizing Aliran Kepercayaan

- **Cables:** Rangkaian telegram Duta Besar Edward Masters (Maret 1978).
- **The Crisis:**
- The New Order government introduced a draft to include *Aliran Kepercayaan terhadap Tuhan Yang Maha Esa* (Indigenous Mystical Faiths) into the GBHN (Broad Guidelines of State Policy).
- Muslim parliamentarians from the United Development Party (PPP) fiercely resisted, viewing this as a state attempt to resurrect syncretic paganism and undermine Islam. On March 22, 1978, PPP members staged a historic walkout from the MPR chamber.
- **The Embassy's Assessment:**
- Ambassador Masters reported to Washington that Soeharto was not acting out of casual political caprice; rather, the recognition of *Kepercayaan* was a deeply personal, ideological imperative for Soeharto.
- The Embassy noted that Soeharto viewed himself as the protector of the authentic, pre-Islamic soul of Java (*Kejawen*), and was using the full coercive weight of the military state apparatus to ensure that Javanese mysticism received permanent, state-protected constitutional legitimacy.

4. The 1998 Banyuwangi "Ninja" & Dukun Santet Killings (Cablegate Archive)

- **Context:** In the chaotic months of 1998, as Indonesia descended into economic collapse and the post-Suharto transition under President B.J. Habibie began, a wave of systematic killings swept East Java.
- **Embassy Jakarta Reporting (Fall 1998 Dispatches):**
- Embassy political officers compiled field reports regarding the killing of over 150 alleged *dukun santet* (black magic practitioners) in Banyuwangi, Jember, and Malang.
- The cables noted the arrival of mysterious masked figures dubbed **"Ninja"**, who were described as possessing extraordinary martial arts agility, operating with tactical precision, and carrying lists of marked individuals.
- **Declassified Intelligence Analysis:**
- U.S. Embassy political officers strongly dismissed the initial official police explanation that these were spontaneous "spontaneous peasant lynchings against evil sorcerers".
- Embassy reporting highlighted findings by independent human rights monitors and Nahdlatul Ulama (NU) investigators showing that the majority of victims were actually local Islamic teachers (*guru ngaji*), traditional mosque custodians, and village NU functionaries.
- The Embassy forwarded assessments to Washington suggesting that rogue military/intelligence elements were conducting a **"black psychological operation"** (*Operasi Pengondisian*): exploiting widespread cultural belief in sorcery as cover to assassinate local grassroots religious leaders, create inter-religious panic, and fabricate a pretext for military intervention to reassert martial law.

5. Post-1998 Presidential Profiles in Diplomatic Cables

With the release of the State Department's *Cablegate* archives (WikiLeaks PlusD), internal diplomatic assessments of later Indonesian presidents revealed how mysticism continued to be evaluated:

5.1. Abdurrahman Wahid (Gus Dur) — Diplomatic Cables (1999–2001)

- Embassy Jakarta cables repeatedly addressed Gus Dur’s unpredictable policy pronouncements and cabinet shuffles.
- Diplomats noted that conventional lobbying techniques were often rendered ineffective because Gus Dur placed immense weight on nocturnal visions, intuitive spiritual premonitions (*firasat*), and consultations at the graves of revered Islamic saints (*ziarah wali*).
- Cables observed that while foreign technocrats found this governance style bewildering, it resonated deeply with tens of millions of traditionalist Javanese voters who regarded Gus Dur as a living saint (*wali*) endowed with esoteric wisdom (*karamah*).

5.2. Megawati Soekarnoputri — The Sacred Heiress

- Embassy reporting during Megawati's vice-presidency and presidency (2001–2004) consistently highlighted the intense spiritual veneration directed toward her by ordinary grassroots supporters (the *Wong Cilik*).

- Cables noted that millions of followers viewed her not merely as a secular party chairwoman, but as the direct biological and spiritual inheritor of Bung Karno's *Wahyu*, attributing to her a maternal, silent protective aura that defied conventional political logic.